its enormous potential, who want to look after their families and neighbours, who are prepared to work hard.

I see these people everywhere, in schools and in offices, in the streets and in the malls, on farms and in villages, in the grandstands and at sponsors' functions; and I genuinely don't see white or black, or coloured or Indian; and I genuinely don't see Christian, Muslim or Hindu. I see only South Africans.

Sometimes we lose sight of the bigger picture.

An amazingly diverse group of people has gathered at the southern tip of the African continent, assembled from so many different backgrounds and cultures and, emerging from a past filled with brutal pain and conflict, these people have somehow managed to unite behind one Constitution and beneath one flag.

The scale of the South African miracle should never be overlooked.

Huge challenges remain – challenges of poverty and inequality, of crime and economic uncertainty, of leadership and corruption – but, in my view, most importantly, there remains in South Africa today a strong sense of shared responsibility, a general acceptance that we're in this together.

This gives me hope.

In many countries that I have visited, people seem somehow defeated, resigned to accepting the status quo and content to blame ongoing problems on the government or bankers or anyone else. In South Africa, maybe naively, tens of millions of us continue to feel personally involved and invested in building the nation.

We have a precious national spirit, a collective drive, a *gees*.

It is the *gees* of the small boy who chases after a ball, who trips and falls, who grazes his knee, who picks himself up with not even a glance at the blood, who runs again and who reaches the ball.

It is the *gees* of the worker who rises at four o'clock every morning and takes three taxis and three hours to get to work and then makes the same trip home, just to provide for his family.